from a more prudish past and yet, for one reason or another, were never repealed. Most of our lives, even if we don't realize it, occur not in black and white but in a gray area, where we jaywalk, put trash in the recycling bin and recyclables in the trash, ride our bicycles in the improper lane, and borrow a stranger's Wi-Fi to download a book that we didn't pay for. Put simply, a world in which every law is always enforced would be a world in which everyone was a criminal.

I tried to talk to Lindsay about all this. But though she was generally sympathetic to my concerns, she wasn't so sympathetic that she was ready to go off the grid, or even off Facebook or Instagram. "If I did that," she said, "I'd be giving up my art and abandoning my friends. You used to like being in touch with other people."

She was right. And she was right to be worried about me. She thought I was too tense, and under too much stress. I was—not because of my work, but because of my desire to tell her a truth that I wasn't allowed to. I couldn't tell her that my former coworkers at the NSA could target her for surveillance and read the love poems she texted me. I couldn't tell her that they could access all the photos she took—not just her public photos, but the intimate ones. I couldn't tell her that her information was being collected, that everyone's information was being collected, which was tantamount to a government threat: If you ever get out of line, we'll use your private life against you.

I tried to explain it to her, obliquely, through an analogy. I told her to imagine opening up her laptop one day and finding a spreadsheet on her desktop.

"Why?" she said. "I don't like spreadsheets."

I wasn't prepared for this response, so I just said the first thing that came to mind. "Nobody does, but this one's called *The End*."

"Ooh, mysterious."

"You don't remember having created this spreadsheet, but once you open it up, you recognize its contents. Because inside it is everything, absolutely everything, that could ruin you. Every speck of information that could destroy your life."

Lindsay smiled. "Can I see the one for you?"

She was joking, but I wasn't. A spreadsheet containing every scrap of data about you would pose a mortal hazard. Imagine it: all the secrets big and small that could end your marriage, end your career, poison even your closest relationships, and leave you broke, friendless, and in prison. Maybe the spreadsheet would include the joint you smoked last weekend at a friend's